# PLAYING IT BY EAR

Run out of things to watch? Tune in to some **audio drama, a welcome addition** to audiences' entertainment choices

BY SUHANI SINGH

**ACTOR, RJ AND AUDIO** writer-producer Mantra Mugdh heard *Sholay* before he saw Ramesh Sippy's 1975 classic. That cassette helped him conjure his own version of Ramgarh and how Jai and Veeru took on Gabbar Singh. In Indore, where he grew up, *Hawa Mahal* on Vividh Bharati, *The Twilight Zone* tapes that a friend had sent from the US and BBC radio dramas filled his days. "It is blind man's TV," says Mugdh, 39, of his fondness for radio. "It helps you create your own pictures in the mind." After two decades in radio, most of them with Fever FM, Mugdh ventured into creating original programming. Much before Audible and Spotify entered India and Pocket FM came up in 2018, he was already uploading audio shows on YouTube and Soundcloud.

Under the banner MnM Talkies, Mugdh and his co-founder, Shimona Mathur, have come up with some of the most popular fiction titles. They include the detective series *Bhaskar Bose*, the longest-running Hindi show on Spotify; *Virus 2062*, an adaptation of a popular Chilean podcast with Richa Chadha and Ali Fazal; and the recently released *Batman: Ek Chakravyuh* (both on Spotify). Helming a team of 15-20 people, he currently has eight audio productions in the running.




MANDAR DEODHAR

**SPELL BOUND** Mantra Mugdh, who produces audio content under the banner MnM Talkies